

Grant Narrative Language

This document provides modular grant narrative language for the Network Delaware “Civic Power” Initiative. It is organized into seven sections corresponding to the aspects most commonly required by civic education and youth development funders. Each section is written as draft language that can be adapted to a specific funder's priorities, vocabulary, and formatting requirements.

I. Statement of Need

The Gap Between Knowledge and Practice

Delaware students learn about democracy, but most are not prepared to practice it. The state's operative K-12 Civics Standards, which were last revised in 2018, contain no statutory mandate, no dedicated funding stream, and no accountability mechanism tied to LEA implementation. The Participation anchor standards, the only standard that requires students to engage with civic agency rather than just acquire knowledge, is only present at the 9th grade level. The Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement (CIRCLE) at Tufts University's 2025 post-election youth survey found that for every form of civic engagement studied, significantly more young people reported willingness to participate if given a structured, supported opportunity than had actually done so. Among 2024 youth voters, 27 percent reported belonging to a movement or organized group, compared to 13 percent of non-voters, a differential that reflects structural access differences, not attitudinal ones (CIRCLE, "25 Things We Learned"). The civic participation gap is a supply-side failure. Delaware's current policy environment does not supply what young people need to close it.

Structural Deficits in Delaware's Current System

Delaware's 2018 Civics Standards carry no statutory mandate, no dedicated funding appropriation, and no accountability structure tied to local education agency (LEA) implementation. The Participation anchor standards, the only anchor requiring students to do something civic rather than understand it, are highlighted once at the 9th grade level. Whether a Delaware student receives any hands-on civic learning depends entirely on the district, teacher, and available professional development. The Academy for Social Civics documents this architecture as oriented primarily around bureaucratic civic knowledge, not civic agency (Academy for Social Civics). This structural failure is not distributed equally. Delaware provides approximately \$1,100 per multilingual learner in opportunity funding, compared with \$6,000 to \$9,000 in New Jersey and Maryland, a funding gap that directly constrains civic education access for the state's fastest-growing student population (WHYY News). New Castle County's

approximately 19,000 multilingual learners, many from immigrant and mixed-status families, face participation barriers that the 2018 standards neither acknowledge nor address. For Black and Brown youth navigating documented school discipline disparities, for LGBTQIA+ students in districts without affirming policies, and for immigrant youth whose access to civic institutions is constrained by enforcement risk, the absence of any safety-conscious or conflict-navigation design in Delaware's civic education framework is not an omission; it is a structural barrier to participation.

The Policy Moment

Governor Matt Meyer's March 2026 Civic Learning Week proclamation and the Delaware Civics Education Coalition's active statewide organizing represent the clearest policy window for meaningful civic education reform in Delaware's recent legislative history (League of Women Voters of Delaware). Legislative momentum requires an evidence-based, community-rooted coalition capacity and an implementation model funders and legislators can point to. Network Delaware has built all three. This proposal funds the infrastructure that converts that readiness into durable statutory reform.

II. Project Description

The Framework Architecture

From Civic Learning to Civic Power is organized around four integrated strategic fronts that advance simultaneously, not sequentially. Front 1 targets the statutory and policy architecture: standards revision, a semester-long civics mandate, a dedicated grant program, and a community accountability structure. Front 2 builds the community infrastructure that makes civic education credible and accessible, community organizations, organizing pathways, and structured family and student voice mechanisms rooted in the priority communities the framework serves. Front 3 centers hands-on civic practice through the Delaware-Ready Civic Power Workshop, which integrates three proven models: the Student Voices and Anoka Action Civics structure, the Gathering for Justice's Justice University organizing curriculum, and Kingian Nonviolence training, turned into a complete civic formation experience. Front 4 is the framework's differentiating investment: strategic nonviolence and leadership development as a required curriculum component, developed through community co-design with the organizations that hold existing trust with Delaware's most vulnerable students.

These four fronts are not interchangeable options! They are mutually reinforcing requirements. A statutory mandate without community power infrastructure produces requirements that under-resourced schools implement inequitably. Community organizing without school-based practice produces energy without entry points. Hands-on civic practice without conflict navigation produces participants who disengage at the first institutional barrier. Strategic

nonviolence without a policy architecture has nowhere to land. The framework's design insists that all four advance together, and that is what makes it different from every existing state model.

At the center of the framework is the Civic Action Cycle: a six-stage, repeatable formation process through which civic learning becomes civic power. The stages, Learn, Analyze, Organize, Act, Teach Back, and Reflect and Iterate, are not curriculum units to be completed once. They are a developmental architecture for building the habits, relationships, and strategic capacities that each subsequent cycle of civic action requires. The framework measures success by what participants can do, analyze, and teach others, not by how many sat through a session.

Front 4 Differentiating Argument

Every state in the comparative field reviewed for this fellowship, Massachusetts, Illinois, Rhode Island, California, New York, and every other 45th state and Puerto Rico, has made some investment in civic education standards, mandate language, or grant infrastructure. Yet none have codified strategic nonviolence and leadership development as a required component. That absence is not a gap in their ambition; it reflects a gap in the field's understanding of what certain student populations actually require from civic education in order to participate without exclusion, harm, or risk.

The research on this point is direct. Studies on civic assets among youth of color find that critical reflection, the ability to identify structural inequity, does not convert into civic action without accompanying civic efficacy: the experience-grounded belief that one's action can produce real change (Wray-Lake et al.). For Black and Brown youth already acutely aware of unjust conditions, civic education that names those conditions without equipping students to engage them strategically produces awareness without agency. That outcome is not incomplete; it is actively discouraging. For immigrant youth whose civic participation carries legal risk, and for LGBTQIA+ students in hostile school environments, the absence of a safety-conscious, conflict-navigation-grounded civic curriculum is not a design oversight. It is a structural exclusion.

The most relevant intellectual tradition for addressing this gap is Kingian Nonviolence, the philosophy and methodology developed from the Civil Rights Movement and systematized in a curriculum co-authored by Dr. Bernard LaFayette, Jr. and David Jehnsen. Kingian Nonviolence is not passivity; it is a disciplined, strategic approach to confronting injustice that requires preparation, collective organization, and skill. A mixed-methods quasi-experimental study with high school students found the Kingian Nonviolence Conflict Reconciliation Training Program associated with improved social and cultural learning outcomes and reduced violence among participants (Cyril). Nonviolent Schools RI has implemented this curriculum in Rhode Island schools with documented climate impacts (Nonviolent Schools RI). Restorative practices research published in *Frontiers in Education* documents that restorative approaches produce significant reductions in school exclusion across racial, gender, and socioeconomic dimensions,

and that their implementation requires an educator belief-system transformation, not merely skill acquisition; a finding with direct implications for Network Delaware's professional development design (García-González et al.).

Delaware has the opportunity to be the first state to codify this component in statute. The evidence base justifies it. The community trust relationships to develop it responsibly already exist. The framework provides the design architecture to do it equitably. This is not a speculative program investment; it is a documented need being met with a documented approach in a jurisdiction positioned to lead the national field.

The Workshop as the Implementation Vehicle

The Delaware-Ready Civic Power Workshop, developed through the Workshop Implementation Framework deliverable of this fellowship, provides the operational vehicle through which Fronts 3 and 4 reach students and community members directly. The workshop runs as either a 90-minute standalone session or a six-session arc over six to eight weeks. Both formats follow the full Civic Action Cycle. The six-session format moves cohorts through issue identification, power analysis, strategy development, direct civic action with a real decision-maker, teach-back with a new audience, and honest reflection on what the action accomplished and what it did not.

What separates this workshop model from standard action civics programs is the leadership pipeline embedded in its structure. Participants who complete the six-session arc can return as observer-analysts. Observer-analysts who complete a facilitation practicum become lead facilitators for new cohorts. This three-tier pipeline is the mechanism through which a workshop becomes a civic infrastructure that replicates itself without proportional increases in external cost. Research on Generation Citizen's action civics model found that the relationship between democratic practice exposure and civic self-efficacy was significantly stronger for Black and Latino youth than for white youth, with safety-themed projects involving direct decision-maker contact producing the strongest gains in future civic commitment (Cohen et al., "Action Civics for Promoting"). The I-ACTED randomized controlled trial, the most methodologically rigorous available evidence on action civics outcomes, confirms that action civics produces positive well-being effects through civic connection and empowerment (Cohen et al., "The I-ACTED Study"). The workshop model is built on this evidence base, not alongside it.

III. Target Population and Equity Design

Six priority communities anchor the equity design of this initiative: immigrant and mixed-status families, Black and Brown youth, Hispanic and Latino communities, disabled students, LGBTQIA+ youth, and multilingual families. These are not populations to be reached after a program is designed; they are the populations for whom the program exists, and their specific structural barriers have shaped every design decision in the framework.

For immigrant and mixed-status families concentrated in New Castle County, the framework provides no-disclosure-required participation pathways, partnership with immigrant-led organizations as trusted intermediaries rather than direct state-led outreach, and rights literacy components embedded in the civic curriculum. For Black and Brown youth, the framework prioritizes culturally sustaining action civics with student-controlled issue selection, paid organizing fellowships that address economic barriers to participation, and civic efficacy development through authentic rather than simulated decision-making. For multilingual families, language access is treated as civic infrastructure, bilingual materials, professional interpretation at all family-facing events, and grant eligibility conditions that make language access a requirement rather than a preference. For disabled students, Universal Design for Learning is applied as a design standard from the first session, not accommodated after the fact. For LGBTQIA+ youth, partnership with Equality Delaware, the United Way of Delaware PRIDE Council, and I Am Me Inc. provides the affirming infrastructure that is a participation prerequisite. The Trevor Project's 2025 research documents that civic engagement correlates with better mental health outcomes among LGBTQIA+ young people, and that participation in affirming school-based organizations is positively associated with broader civic agency (The Trevor Project). Inclusive civic design is not a political concession; it is an evidence-based mechanism for building civic capacity in a population that is both highly motivated and structurally underserved.

IV. Implementation Plan

Network Delaware proposes a three-phase implementation strategy designed to pilot, document, and scale the framework across Delaware's three counties.

Phase One, spanning the first year, focuses on structured piloting and community co-design. Three to five workshop sites will be launched across New Castle, Kent, and Sussex Counties, prioritizing sites with the majority of students of color and significant immigrant or multilingual populations. Simultaneously, Network Delaware will convene the Front 4 community co-design process, bringing together La Esperanza, the Latin American Community Center, Equality Delaware, the United Way of Delaware PRIDE Council, disability advocacy organizations, and youth-led groups alongside DCCE and Delaware Civics Education Coalition staff. The co-design process has decision-making authority over the strategic nonviolence curriculum content, not review authority over an externally produced product. The distinction matters: a curriculum developed without genuine community co-authorship will not be trusted, will not be culturally relevant, and will not produce the civic efficacy outcomes the evidence identifies as the mechanism of change. Phase One ends with a documented learning report available to funders and policy partners.

Phase Two, spanning years two and three, uses pilot documentation to train fifteen to twenty lead facilitators, expand to ten to fifteen implementation sites, and advance the Front 1 legislative

strategy using the Policy Brief and pilot evaluation data as the primary evidence base. The standards revision process, the Civic Education Grant Program advocacy, and the Community Accountability Structure design all advance in parallel during Phase Two, coordinated through the Delaware Civics Education Coalition.

Phase Three, spanning years three through five, activates the full three-tier leadership pipeline described in the Workshop Implementation Framework. New lead facilitators develop faster than existing ones, cycle out. Institutional partnerships are maintained through documented Memoranda of Understanding established during the pilot phase. LEA partnerships produce structured civic action capstones at the district level. The program becomes self-sustaining, not because the need diminishes, but because the capacity to meet it has been built into Delaware's civic infrastructure rather than dependent on continued external support.

V. Evaluation Design

The framework measures success by what participants can do, analyze, and teach others. Network Delaware will track six outcome domains across all implementation sites, derived directly from the Civic Action Cycle: civic knowledge, assessed by whether participants can explain how a real decision they engaged was made; civic analysis, assessed by power mapping and structural diagnosis exercises; organizing capacity, assessed by facilitator observation of leadership role uptake and peer recruitment; civic action, documented through activity logs and decision-maker engagement records; teach-back, documented through participant self-report and facilitated session records; and reflection and iteration, assessed through end-of-cycle debrief forms.

For the Front 4 strategic nonviolence curriculum, evaluation is built into the pilot design from the outset. Pre- and post-assessments of civic efficacy, conflict navigation self-assessment, and facilitator observation records will be reviewed on a structured cycle, with community partner feedback incorporated before any revision to curriculum content. Network Delaware will share annual evaluation findings with the Delaware Civics Education Coalition, the DDOE, and philanthropic partners. Evaluation data will be disaggregated by priority community to ensure that aggregate gains do not mask inequitable distribution of outcomes.

VI. Organizational Capacity and Partnerships

Network Delaware brings three institutional assets to this initiative that no other Delaware organization currently combines. The first is genuine community trust with the priority populations this framework serves, built through years of organizing work, not program delivery. That trust is the condition of possibility for the Front 4 co-design process. Curricula imposed on communities without their authorship do not produce the outcomes the evidence promises. The second is policy research and advocacy capacity: the seven fellowship deliverables produced for this proposal represent a complete evidence infrastructure, from the Delaware landscape review

through the comparative state analysis, the youth civic engagement memo, the strategic nonviolence brief, the partnership toolkit, the workshop framework, and this grant narrative. The third is organizational infrastructure, the Organizing Fellowship, community coaching networks, and statewide partner relationships that make the workshop model replicable at scale rather than dependent on any single facilitator or program site.

Key institutional partners include the Delaware Center for Civic Education at the University of Delaware Biden School; the Delaware Civics Education Coalition; CIRCLE at Tufts University; the Latin American Community Center; La Esperanza; the Delaware Hispanic Commission; Equality Delaware; the United Way of Delaware PRIDE Council; and disability advocacy organizations statewide. The School and Community Partnership Toolkit produced through this fellowship establishes the Memorandum of Understanding protocols, partner readiness criteria, and equity design standards that will govern every partnership relationship in the implementation phase.

VII. Conclusion: The Investment Case

The case for this investment is empirical. Students who experience structured action civics, connected to real community decisions, guided by teachers trained in power-conscious facilitation, and supported by organizations with existing community trust, develop stronger civic identity, greater civic self-efficacy, and higher rates of long-term civic participation, with the strongest effects among students from historically marginalized communities (Cohen et al., "Action Civics for Promoting"; Wray-Lake et al.; CIRCLE, "Youth Are Taking Civic Action"). Delaware is small enough that statewide coordination is achievable. It has a civic education coalition with active organizing capacity, executive-level support for civic learning, and a diverse population whose communities stand to gain the most from genuine civic power.

What Delaware lacks is the statutory, financial, and community accountability architecture to make equitable civic education reliably available. Not dependent on the right district, the right teacher, or an individual school leader's discretion. From Civic Learning to Civic Power is the proposal for building that architecture. This grant narrative is the investment case for making it real. Network Delaware asks funders to join a project that measures success not by how many students sat in a classroom, but by how many left it capable of building power, navigating conflict, and teaching what they learned to someone else.

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